

BrandBridge AI

Complete guide to every feature, role and workflow

"Stop competing for budget. Start collaborating for growth."

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1 What BrandBridge AI does

BrandBridge AI is a collaboration marketplace. Instead of every brand buying its own audience, two compatible brands partner on a shared campaign — splitting the cost while doubling the reach. The platform finds the partner, drafts the outreach, generates the campaign assets, and brings in freelance creatives to produce the work.

The problem it solves

A small brand spends its entire marketing budget acquiring an audience another brand already has. If a coffee roaster and a bakery share the same customer, they are competing for the same ad impressions rather than sharing them. BrandBridge AI makes that introduction, then handles the paperwork and production around it.

Core concepts

Concept	What it means
Match	An AI-scored compatibility rating (0–100%) between two brands, based on audience overlap, industry alignment and shared goals
Collaboration	A partnership between two brands. Starts as a request, becomes active once accepted
Campaign	The actual marketing initiative run under a collaboration — with a budget, dates, goals and milestones
Project	A piece of creative work posted for freelancers to bid on
Proposal	A freelancer's bid on a project
Hire	An engaged freelancer working on agreed deliverables at an agreed rate
Product	An item a Product Owner wants brands to promote

The four roles

Your role is chosen once during onboarding and determines your entire dashboard. Each role sees a different sidebar, different statistics and different pages.

Role	You are...	You mainly do
Brand	A business with an audience and a marketing budget	Find partner brands, run joint campaigns, hire creatives
Product Owner	Someone with a product needing exposure	List products, find brands to promote them, track performance
Freelancer	A designer, editor, copywriter or similar	Showcase work, bid on projects, get hired, track earnings
Hirer	Someone who needs creative talent directly	Browse freelancers, post projects, manage hires

One role per account

A role is selected at onboarding and the app routes you to that role's dashboard on every login. Visiting another role's URL redirects you back to your own. To work in a different role you need a separate account.

2 Getting the app running

Install and start

```
npm install
npm run dev # http://localhost:3000
```

All commands

Command	Does
npm run dev	Development server with hot reload
npm run build	Production build
npm start	Serve the production build
npm run lint	ESLint
npm test	Run the test suite once
npm run test:watch	Tests in watch mode
npm run test:coverage	Tests with a coverage report

Environment variables

These live in `.env.local`. The app degrades gracefully when the optional ones are absent.

Variable	Required	Purpose
MONGODB_URI	Yes	Database connection
JWT_SECRET	Yes	Signs session tokens
GEMINI_API_KEY	Recommended	Powers all AI features. Without it, AI routes return curated fallback text instead of failing
EMAIL_USER EMAIL_APP_PASSWORD	Yes	Sends OTP and password-reset emails
GOOGLE_CLIENT_ID GOOGLE_CLIENT_SECRET GOOGLE_REDIRECT_URI	Optional	Enables "Continue with Google"
CLOUDINARY_CLOUD_NAME CLOUDINARY_API_KEY CLOUDINARY_API_SECRET	Optional	Image hosting. Without these, uploads fall back to inline base64 storage
NEXT_PUBLIC_APP_URL	Yes	Base URL used in emails, sitemap and Open Graph tags

The AI keeps working without a key

Every AI route has a hand-written fallback response. If `GEMINI_API_KEY` is missing or the Gemini call fails, the user still gets sensible sample output rather than an error — useful for demos, but remember the output is then generic rather than tailored.

3 Creating an account

The signup flow



Step 1 — Sign up

Go to `/signup`. Enter your name, email and password. The password strength meter updates live as you type. Submitting sends a one-time code to your email address.

Step 2 — Verify the code

You land on `/verify-otp`. Enter the six-digit code from your inbox. The field auto-advances between boxes and accepts a pasted code. A countdown shows when you may request a new code.

Step 3 and 4

Covered in section 4 — you cannot reach the dashboard until both are done.

Signing in with Google

Press “Continue with Google” on either the login or signup page. Google-authenticated accounts skip OTP verification, since Google has already verified the address. You still choose a role and complete a profile.

Google accounts have no password on the platform, so the change-password section of settings is hidden for them.

Forgotten password



Enter your email at `/forgot-password` and a reset link is sent. The link carries a single-use token; opening it takes you to `/reset-password` where you set a new password. Requesting a reset does not reveal whether an account exists, which prevents the form being used to discover registered addresses.

4 Onboarding

Choosing your role

At `/onboarding/role` you pick one of the four roles from section 1. This is the single most important choice in the app — it determines your navigation, your dashboard and which features exist for you at all. Read the four descriptions before choosing.

Completing your profile

At `/onboarding/profile` you fill in the fields your role requires. **The app blocks access to the dashboard until the profile is marked complete**, so this is not optional.

What each role is asked for

Role	Fields that count toward completeness
Brand	Company name, logo, bio, industry, location, website, target audience, budget range, collaboration preferences, business type — ten fields, each worth 10%
Freelancer	Profile photo, bio, location, at least one skill, a category, an hourly rate above zero, and at least one portfolio item — seven checks
Product Owner / Hirer	Company name, bio, industry, target audience — four fields, each worth 25%

The completeness widget

Your profile page shows a live percentage bar with the specific fields still missing, phrased as actions — “Upload brand logo”, “Set hourly rate”. Completeness matters beyond tidiness: brand matching quality depends on how much the AI knows about you, and freelancers with incomplete profiles surface lower in the marketplace.

Empty is not the same as zero

For freelancers, an hourly rate of `0` counts as unset, not as “free”. Set a real rate or the check stays unfilled.

5 Finding your way around

The sidebar

On the left at desktop widths, and behind the ☰ menu button on phones and tablets. It shows your role badge, your role's pages, your account, and the logout button. Tapping any link on mobile closes the drawer automatically.

The header

Control	Does
☰ Menu	Opens the sidebar drawer. Only visible below the lg breakpoint
 Search	Opens global search. Keyboard shortcut <code>Ctrl + K</code> (<code>⌘ + K</code> on Mac)
☀/🌙 Theme	Toggles light and dark. Your choice persists across sessions
 Bell	Notification panel with an unread badge. "Mark all read" clears the count

Global search

Press `Ctrl + K` anywhere in the dashboard to search across your records without navigating. Press it again, or `Esc`, to close.

Working on a phone

- The sidebar becomes a slide-in drawer with a dimmed backdrop; tap outside to dismiss
- Tab strips scroll horizontally rather than wrapping — swipe them sideways
- Messages show one pane at a time: the conversation list, then the chat, with a back arrow
- The context panel opens as a bottom sheet instead of a side column

6 Brand role guide

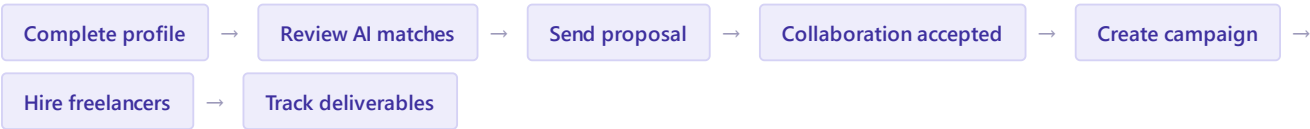
Brand

A business with an audience and a budget, looking for partners to campaign with

Your pages

Page	Purpose
Dashboard	Statistics, AI recommendations, pending proposals, quick actions
My Profile	Four-section brand profile with a live completeness meter
AI Brand Matching	Scored partner suggestions
Collaborations	Partnership requests and active partnerships
Campaigns	Marketing initiatives under your collaborations
Hire Freelancers	The creative marketplace
My Hires	Freelancers currently engaged, and their deliverables
Messages	Conversations with partners and freelancers
Settings	Account, password, security, deletion

The complete brand workflow



6.1 AI brand matching

The matching page scores potential partners from 0–100% using your industry, audience definition and stated collaboration goals — which is exactly why profile completeness matters. Each card shows the score, why the brands fit, and actions to open the full profile, save the match, or start outreach.

Alongside registered brands the page can surface **external brand suggestions** — companies not yet on the platform that the AI identifies as a good fit, useful for offline outreach.

Sending outreach

Choosing a match and pressing outreach opens the **AI-drafted email modal**. The draft is generated from both brands' profiles. Always read and edit it before sending — it is a starting point, not a finished email.

6.2 Collaborations

A collaboration is **pending** until the other brand responds, then **accepted** or **declined**. Incoming requests appear here with accept and decline actions; opening one shows the full partner profile and the proposal text.

6.3 Campaigns

Campaigns run under an accepted collaboration — you cannot create one without a partner, which is deliberate, since a campaign is by definition shared. Press **New Campaign** and provide:

- Campaign name and the linked collaboration
- Type — co-branded social post, product bundle, influencer push, cross-promotion, or other
- Goal — awareness, sales, engagement or reach
- Start and end dates, and the budget

Campaign status moves through **draft**, **active**, **paused**, **completed** or **cancelled**. Opening a campaign shows performance metrics and the cost split between both brands.

6.4 Hiring freelancers

The marketplace lists verified creatives filterable by category, skill, rate and rating. Opening a freelancer shows their bio, portfolio, skills and reviews. **Hire** opens a form for the agreed rate, the deadline, an optional linked campaign, and the deliverables expected.

Hires progress through **pending** → **active** → **completed**, or **cancelled**. Under **My Hires** you review submitted deliverables and leave a review once work is complete.

7 Product Owner role guide

Product Owner

You have a product; you need brands with audiences to put it in front of

Your pages

Page	Purpose
Dashboard	Customisable widget grid with KPIs, AI insights, tasks, meetings and goals
Find Brands	Discover and request promotion from brands
My Products	Product catalogue with per-product analytics
Campaigns	Three-step campaign wizard with milestones and ROI
Analytics	Cross-product performance
AI Hub	Five AI tools in one console
Messages · Profile · Settings	As other roles

7.1 Managing products

Add a product with its name, description, category, pricing and images. Status is `draft`, `active` or `archived` — **only active products can be attached to campaigns or shown to brands**, so remember to activate after drafting.

Opening a product shows an image gallery, an analytics panel, and an AI marketing generator that produces copy, SEO tags or hashtags for that specific product.

7.2 The dashboard customiser

Press **Customize** in the dashboard toolbar to show or hide individual widgets — KPIs, AI insights, quick actions, recent activity, upcoming meetings, goal progress and the performance chart. The toolbar also opens the notification centre, the task board, saved reports and the document library.

7.3 The campaign wizard



Step one captures the title, description and linked active product. Step two sets milestones — pre-filled with a sensible default sequence (contract signed, content draft approval, campaign live) that you can edit. Step three sets the budget and shows the projected return.

An **Ask AI** button at any step suggests content and positioning ideas for the campaign you are describing. Creating a campaign also registers a workflow automation that generates tasks and notifies your team when the campaign is approved.

7.4 AI Hub

Five tools sharing one console. Pick a tool, fill the prompt, and the result appears in a copyable panel:

Tool	Produces
Consultant	Strategic answers to collaboration questions
SWOT	Strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats for a product or brand
Proposal	A full partnership proposal between a named sender and recipient
Social	Three caption variants with hashtags
Pricing	A tiered rate sheet with estimated ROI per tier

8 Freelancer role guide

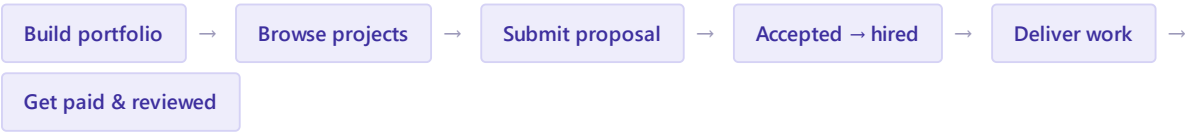
Freelancer

A designer, editor, copywriter or other creative looking for campaign work

Your pages

Page	Purpose
Dashboard	Active projects, pending hire requests, opportunities, earnings, skill ratings
My Portfolio	Work samples shown to prospective clients
Browse Projects	Open projects you can bid on
Proposals	Bids you have submitted and their outcomes
Earnings	Income, completed jobs and payment status
Messages · Profile · Settings	As other roles

The freelancer workflow



8.1 Portfolio first

Do this before anything else. Your profile is not complete without at least one portfolio item, and an incomplete profile keeps you out of marketplace results. Each item takes a title, description, media and a category.

8.2 Projects and proposals

Browse Projects lists work with status `open`. Each shows the budget — `fixed` or `hourly` — the scope and the skills wanted. Submitting a proposal records your bid amount, timeline and pitch.

Proposals are `pending`, then `accepted` or `rejected`. You may `withdraw` your own proposal while it is still pending. An accepted proposal becomes a hire.

8.3 Hire requests and delivery

A brand or hirer can also approach you directly. Pending hire requests appear on your dashboard with the offered rate, deadline and deliverables — accept or decline from there. Once active, upload deliverables against the hire; the client reviews them and can then leave a rating.

8.4 Earnings

Totals, completed job count and per-hire payment status. Figures derive from your hire records, so they update as hires move to `completed`.

9 Hirer role guide

Hirer

You need creative talent directly, without running a brand collaboration

The Hirer role is the lightest of the four: talent sourcing and project management, without the brand-matching and collaboration machinery.

Your pages

Page	Purpose
Dashboard	Saved freelancers, active hires, open projects, message count
Browse Freelancers	The marketplace, filterable by category
Projects	Work you have posted, and the proposals received
My Hires	Engaged freelancers and their deliverables
Messages · Profile · Settings	As other roles

The hirer workflow



Two routes to a hire

Post and wait — create a project with a title, scope, budget type and amount, and required skills. Freelancers bid; you compare proposals and accept one.

Search and approach — browse the marketplace, open a freelancer, and hire them directly with an agreed rate and deliverables. Save interesting freelancers for later; they appear on your dashboard.

Projects move through `open` → `in_progress` → `completed`, or `closed` if you stop taking bids.

10 Messaging

Every role has the same messaging centre, reachable from the sidebar or from any profile via a message button.

Layout

Three panes at desktop width: the conversation list, the chat, and an optional context panel. On phones these become one screen at a time with a back arrow.

What you can do

Action	How
Send a message	Type and press enter, or the send button
Attach a file	Paperclip icon. Attachments upload before the message sends
Edit a message	Pencil icon on your own messages
Unsend	Bin icon on your own messages. The bubble becomes "This message was unsent"
Filter conversations	Type chips above the list — collaboration, freelancer hire, product promotion
Archive	From the conversation menu
Block someone	From the conversation menu, with a confirmation step
Summarise a thread	AI summary of a long conversation
Open context	Shows the related collaboration, hire or product beside the chat

Messages arrive on their own

The chat refreshes every 5 seconds and the conversation list every 15, so a message from the other person appears without you reloading. Refreshing pauses while the browser tab is in the background, and the view will not scroll away from you while you are reading older messages.

Editing on a phone

The edit and unsend controls sit beside your own message bubbles. On touch devices they are always visible; at desktop widths they appear on hover to keep the thread clean.

11 AI features reference

All AI features run on Google Gemini and require you to be signed in.

Feature	Where	What it produces
Brand matching	Brand · Matching	Compatibility scores with reasoning
Product matching	Product Owner · Brands	Brands suited to a specific product
External brands	Brand · Matching	Off-platform companies worth approaching
Outreach email	Match card	A ready-to-edit introduction email
Proposal	Matching · AI Hub	A full partnership proposal
Campaign brief	Campaigns	A structured brief for a campaign
Content ideas	Campaigns	Cross-platform content concepts
Message assistance	Messages	Reply suggestions and thread summaries
AI Hub	Product Owner	Consultant, SWOT, proposal, social, pricing

Usage limits

To keep costs predictable, AI requests are capped per user:

Limit	Allowance	Applies to
Per individual feature	12 per minute	Each AI endpoint separately
Across all AI features	30 per minute	Everything combined

Exceeding a limit returns a message telling you how many seconds to wait. Nothing is lost — retry after the countdown.

When AI output looks generic

Two causes. Either `GEMINI_API_KEY` is not configured, so the route is serving its built-in fallback text; or your profile is thin, leaving the model little to work with. Completing your profile measurably improves match and proposal quality.

Always review AI output before it leaves the platform

Outreach emails, proposals and campaign copy are drafts. They can contain plausible but incorrect details about either brand. Read them properly before sending.

12 Settings and security

Settings lives at `/dashboard/<your-role>/settings` and has four sections.

Account

Update your display name and email address. Changing an email requires verifying the new address before it takes effect — until then the old address stays active and the pending change is shown.

Password

Requires your current password plus the new one. Hidden entirely for Google-authenticated accounts, which have no platform password.

Security

Two-factor authentication



The app generates a QR code for any authenticator app — Google Authenticator, Authy, 1Password. Scan it, then confirm with a generated code. 2FA is only active once that confirmation succeeds, which prevents locking yourself out with a mis-scanned code.

Active sessions

Lists every device signed into your account with its browser, operating system and last-active time. Revoke any session you do not recognise; that device is signed out immediately.

Deleting your account

Permanent. You must type your email address to confirm, and password-based accounts must also supply their password. Do this only if you are certain — there is no undo.

Notifications

Notification preferences are stored per account and control which platform events reach you.

13 Status reference

Every record type has a defined lifecycle. This table is the authoritative list.

Record	Statuses
Collaboration	<code>pending</code> · <code>accepted</code> · <code>declined</code>
Campaign	<code>draft</code> · <code>active</code> · <code>paused</code> · <code>completed</code> · <code>cancelled</code>
Project	<code>open</code> · <code>in_progress</code> · <code>completed</code> · <code>closed</code>
Proposal	<code>pending</code> · <code>accepted</code> · <code>rejected</code> · <code>withdrawn</code>
Hire	<code>pending</code> · <code>active</code> · <code>completed</code> · <code>cancelled</code>
Product	<code>draft</code> · <code>active</code> · <code>archived</code>
Task	<code>todo</code> · <code>in_progress</code> · <code>done</code> — priority <code>low</code> / <code>medium</code> / <code>high</code>

Conversation types

Every conversation is tagged `collaboration` , `freelancer_hire` or `product_promotion` , which drives the filter chips and the context panel.

Automation triggers

Workflow automations can fire on: campaign approved, collaboration accepted, task completed, product activated, project approved, hire accepted, payment released, project completed, and promotion accepted. Available actions are: create a task, notify the team, generate a report, and send an email.

14 Troubleshooting

Symptom	Cause and fix
Redirected to profile completion repeatedly	A required field is still empty. The completeness widget names exactly which one
Cannot create a campaign	Campaigns require an <i>accepted</i> collaboration. A pending one is not enough
Product not selectable in a campaign	Only active products can be linked. Change it from draft
"Too many AI requests"	You hit the rate limit. Wait the number of seconds shown
AI output feels generic	Either GEMINI_API_KEY is unset and fallback text is being served, or your profile is too sparse
Not appearing in the freelancer marketplace	Your profile is incomplete — most often a missing portfolio item or an hourly rate of zero
Signed out unexpectedly	The session was revoked from Settings → Security, or the password changed on another device
Another role's URL bounces back	Expected. Accounts are locked to one role
Images not loading after upload	Cloudinary credentials are probably missing, so uploads fall back to inline base64 — functional, but heavy on large files
OTP email never arrives	Check spam, then verify EMAIL_USER and EMAIL_APP_PASSWORD . A Gmail <i>app password</i> is required, not the account password
"This section could not be loaded"	A request failed. Press Retry — your data is unaffected

Getting help

When an error screen shows a reference code, quote it — it matches an entry in the server logs and identifies the exact failure.

Keyboard shortcuts

Ctrl + **K** opens global search from anywhere in the dashboard. **Esc** closes any open modal.